Even as it spreads its wings, a rising India must remain focussed on its immediate neighbourhood and the extended one. The current decade has seen a radical improvement in India's linkages as a result of the Neighbourhood First policy. Whether it is rail, road, air or waterway connectivity; supply of energy; restoration of heritage; construction of housing; or expansion of capacities, India has demonstrated the value of its friendship. Neighbours are increasingly realizing that India can be a source of prosperity for them as well. In difficult times, especially during Covid, their well-being was greatly enhanced by contributions from India. Those who faced serious balance of payments crisis, like Sri Lanka, could also turn to India for support. As a result, the sense of regional togetherness has grown steadily.

That has also been the case with the regions a little more extended from India. ASEAN has discovered in India a firm advocate of its centrality and cohesion. The agenda of cooperation has widened to cover connectivity, development assistance, research and education, as well as security. The Gulf has seen a degree of attention that has been missing for the last four decades. The stresses of the Covid period have only intensified this growing closeness. The levels of investment, trade and strategic collaboration have improved markedly.

With Central Asia, too, the template of comprehensive engagement announced in 2022 has opened up possibilities in a wide range of domains. Indian capacities and partners are being explored with a much greater sense of enthusiasm.

As for the island neighbours of the Indian Ocean, they have seen India come through in both difficult and routine times. The overall picture that emerges is now of an India that is more engaged, more responsible, more contributive and, therefore, more reliable.

GLOBAL SOUTH AND GLOBAL GOOD

As it ascends the international hierarchy, India speaks not just for itself but for a larger Global South constituency as well. The last few years have been particularly tough on developing countries. The impact of Covid was much harder, whether in terms of health accessibility or affordability. That they were then subjected to travel restraints added insult to injury. Already fragile economies reeled under the weight of lockdowns and disruptions,